

How Reality Becomes Compressed

The Civilization Compression Stack and Reality Drift

Reality Drift Framework — Representational Systems Brief #2

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The Basic Pattern

Civilizations cannot operate directly on raw reality.

Reality is too complex, local, contradictory, and constantly changing.

To coordinate at scale, societies continually compress reality into increasingly simpler representations.

The basic sequence is:

reality → science → institutions → media → public narrative → individual belief

Each layer preserves enough information to remain useful.

Each layer also leaves something behind.

Compression is not a mistake.

It is the price of coordination.

Why Compression Is Necessary

No person can experience every event.

No institution can evaluate every situation independently.

No society can coordinate without shared abstractions.

Science compresses countless observations into general principles.

Institutions compress principles into procedures.

Media compresss events into stories.

Public narratives compress stories into shared interpretations.

Individuals inherit those interpretations as beliefs about how the world works.

Civilizations scale by compressing complexity into forms that can be communicated, remembered, and acted upon.

What Gets Lost

Every layer keeps something.

Every layer discards something.

Reality contains contradiction, local context, uncertainty, and exception.

Science necessarily simplifies.

Institutions standardize.

Media select.

Narratives reinforce.

Beliefs stabilize.

None of these layers are inherently deceptive.

But each becomes less complete than the one before it.

The result is not falsehood.

It is progressive reduction.

The Compression Stack

Reality

Reality is rich, dynamic, contradictory, and independent of our descriptions.

Science

Science compresses countless observations into models, theories, and generalizations.

Institutions

Institutions convert those generalizations into repeatable rules, standards, and procedures.

Media

Media selects which events become visible and how they are framed.

Public Narrative

Public narratives simplify media into widely shared explanations about what is happening and why.

Individual Belief

Individuals inherit these compressed representations and use them to interpret future experience.

Very few people begin from reality.

Most begin from inherited representations of reality.

Compression and Reality Drift

Within the **Reality Drift framework**, compression becomes dangerous when each layer becomes more responsive to the compressed layer above it than the richer layer below it.

Institutions respond to narratives.

Narratives respond to media.

Media responds to incentives.

Beliefs respond to narratives.

Direct contact with reality becomes increasingly rare.

Eventually, representations begin shaping one another more than they are shaped by the world.

This is **recursive compression**.

Reality remains the source.

But it is no longer the primary reference point.

Why Modern Life Feels Increasingly Mediated

Digital systems accelerate every stage of the compression stack.

Information moves faster.

Representations circulate farther.

Algorithms amplify successful patterns.

AI systems generate new representations from previous representations.

The distance between lived experience and inherited belief can expand without anyone intentionally distorting reality.

Compression compounds.

Each generation inherits a world already filtered by the last.

The Core Principle

Compression makes civilization possible.

Without it, large societies could not coordinate.

The danger is forgetting that compressed representations remain approximations rather than reality itself.

As compression increases, coordination becomes easier.

Direct contact becomes harder.

People rarely encounter reality directly. They inherit increasingly compressed versions of it.

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